

Introduction

The phrase 'differently abled' emerged in the 1980s as a positive alternative to terms like 'disabled' or 'handicapped', aiming to promote inclusivity and avoid discrimination. It's crucial to distinguish between disability and disorder:

- **Disability:** A permanent physical or mental condition.
- **Disorder:** Can be temporary or permanent.

Adaptive or Disability Sports

These are competitive sports specially designed for individuals with disabilities. They often involve modifications to rules or equipment to accommodate participants' special needs.

- **Example:** Sled hockey allows players to use sleds.

Special Olympics

- **Founder:** Eunice Kennedy Shriver (1968)
- **Purpose:** Provide year-round sports training and athletic competition for individuals with intellectual disabilities.
- **Benefits:** Develop physical fitness, experience sportsmanship, foster friendships.
- **Headquarters:** Washington D.C.
- **Motto:** "Let me win. But if I can't win, let me be brave in the attempt."
- **Governing Body:** Special Olympics International
- **Logo:** Based on the sculpture 'Joy and Happiness to all Children of the World'.
- **Flame:** 'Flame of Hope'.
- **First Games:** Chicago, USA (1968)
- **Recent Games:** Berlin, Germany (2023)
- **Sports:** Skiing (Alpine, Cross-country), Swimming, Gymnastics, Speed Skating, Handball, Netball, Equestrian, Athletics, Softball, Judo, Figure Skating, Badminton, Powerlifting, Floorball, Basketball.

Paralympics

- **Description:** International multi-sport event for athletes with a range of disabilities.
- **Frequency:** Every two years, usually after the Olympic Games.
- **Versions:** Summer and Winter Games.
- **Governing Body:** International Paralympic Committee (IPC)
- **Headquarters:** Bonn, Germany.
- **Motto:** "Spirit in Motion" (since 2004, Athens). Previous motto: "Mind, Body, Spirit" (1994).
- **Participants:** Athletes with impaired muscle power, hypertonina, ataxia, vision impairment, intellectual impairment, etc.
- **Logo:** Three Agitos (meaning "I move" in Latin) encircling a central point, symbolizing motion and global unity of athletes.
- **Disability Categories:** Cerebral palsy, amputee, visual impairment, intellectual disability, spinal cord injuries, and "les autres" (other non-fitting disabilities like Dwarfism).
- **First Games:** Rome, Italy (Summer, 1960)
- **Recent Games:** Beijing, China (2022)
- **Sports:** Athletics, Archery, Badminton, Boccia, Canoeing, Cycling, Equestrian, Football 5-a-side, Goalball, Rowing, Shooting, Judo, Powerlifting, Sitting Volleyball, Swimming, Table Tennis, Triathlon, Taekwondo, Wheelchair Basketball, Wheelchair Fencing, Wheelchair Tennis, Wheelchair Rugby.

Deaflympics

- **Description:** International Olympic event for deaf athletes.
- **Key Feature:** Unlike other events, athletes cannot be guided by sound cues (whistle, gunshot). Special arrangements like waving flags or using lights are made.
- **Significance:** World's second oldest multi-sport event after the Olympics, and fastest-growing. Equivalent to Olympic Games for deaf athletes.
- **Motto:** "PER LUDOS AEQUALITAS" (Equality through sport)
- **Logo:** Inspired by the sign for Olympics; central circle represents an eye (deaf people are very visual). Four colors (red, green, yellow, blue) represent the four regional confederations of the International Committee of Sports for Deaf (Europe, Asia Pacific, Pan-America, Africa).
- **Purpose:** Provide opportunities for individuals with hearing disability to participate in elite sports.
- **Eligibility:** Minimum 55 decibel hearing loss in the better ear. Hearing aids/cochlear implants are not allowed during competition.
- **Summer Sports:** Athletics, Badminton, Basketball, Beach Volleyball, Bowling, Cycling Road, Football, Handball, Judo, Shooting, Karate, Orienteering, Swimming, Table Tennis.

- **Winter Sports:** Alpine skiing, Cross-country skiing, Curling, Ice Hockey, Snowboard.

Strategies to Make Physical Activities Accessible for CWSN

- **Medical Check-up:** Essential to understand the specific disabilities of children to tailor activities appropriately.
- **Assistive Technology:** Use specialized equipment (e.g., balls with bells, larger balls, tethered balls) to aid participation.
- **Creating a Specific Environment:** Design friendly spaces that consider their needs (e.g., natural lighting instead of glaring lights, adjusted sound levels).
- **Activities Based on Interests:** Align activities with children's interests, aptitudes, abilities, and previous experiences.
- **Modification of Rules:** Adjust rules to provide extra time, attempts, or rest periods.
- **Children's Previous Experience:** Teachers should understand a child's prior experience with physical activities to better support them.
- **Specialized Equipment:** Customize equipment size, weight, shape, and color (e.g., brightly colored for visually impaired, lighter for weak muscles).

Advantages of Physical Activities for CWSN

- **Reduce Depression & Stress:** Helps lower anxiety and stress levels.
- **Improve Social Interaction:** Provides opportunities for social engagement, leading to increased social integration, friendship, and bonding.
- **Many Cognitive Benefits:** Enhances thinking, reasoning, and memory skills; helps discover strengths outside the classroom.
- **Fun Activities:** Boosts mood and provides enjoyment through social interaction.
- **Increased Fitness & Strength Levels:** Improves muscle strength, coordination, flexibility, motor skills, balance, and body awareness.
- **Improve Health Quality:** Leads to positive health outcomes, increased self-esteem, a sense of accomplishment, better appetite, and improved sleep quality.
- **Decreases Other Health Issues:** Reduces risks of secondary complications like obesity, high blood pressure, low HDL cholesterol, and diabetes.

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